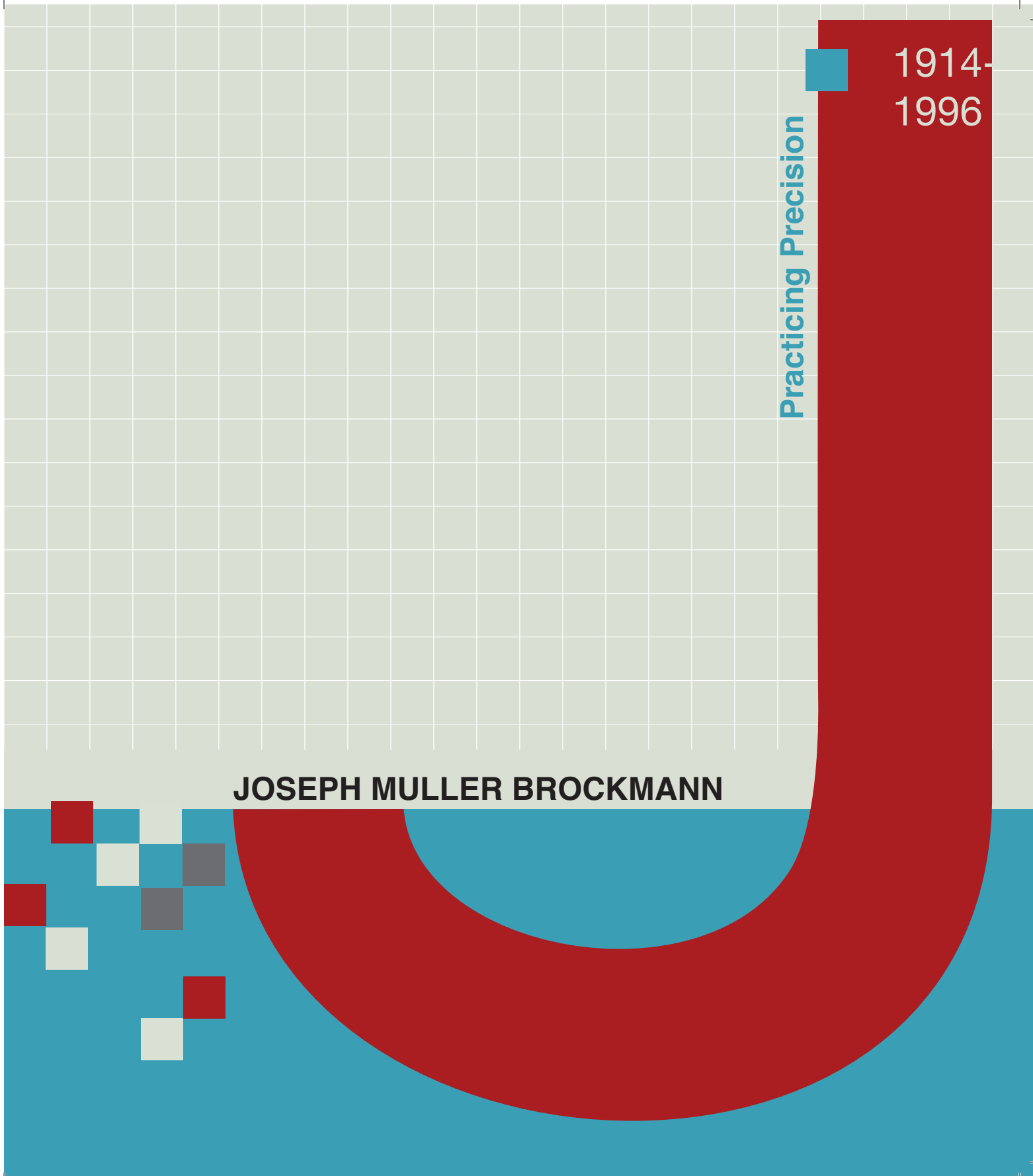


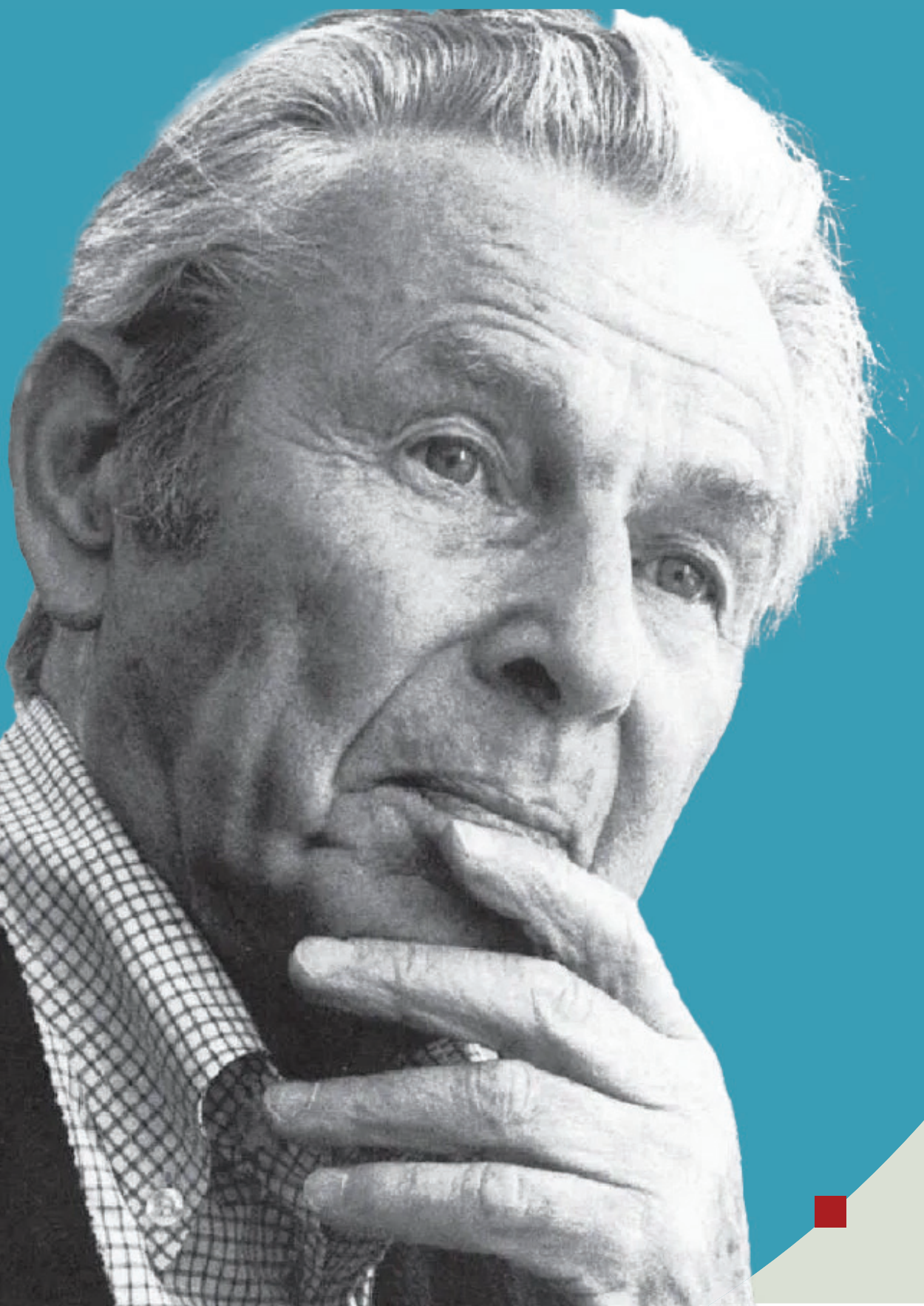
JOSEPH MULLER BROCKMANN

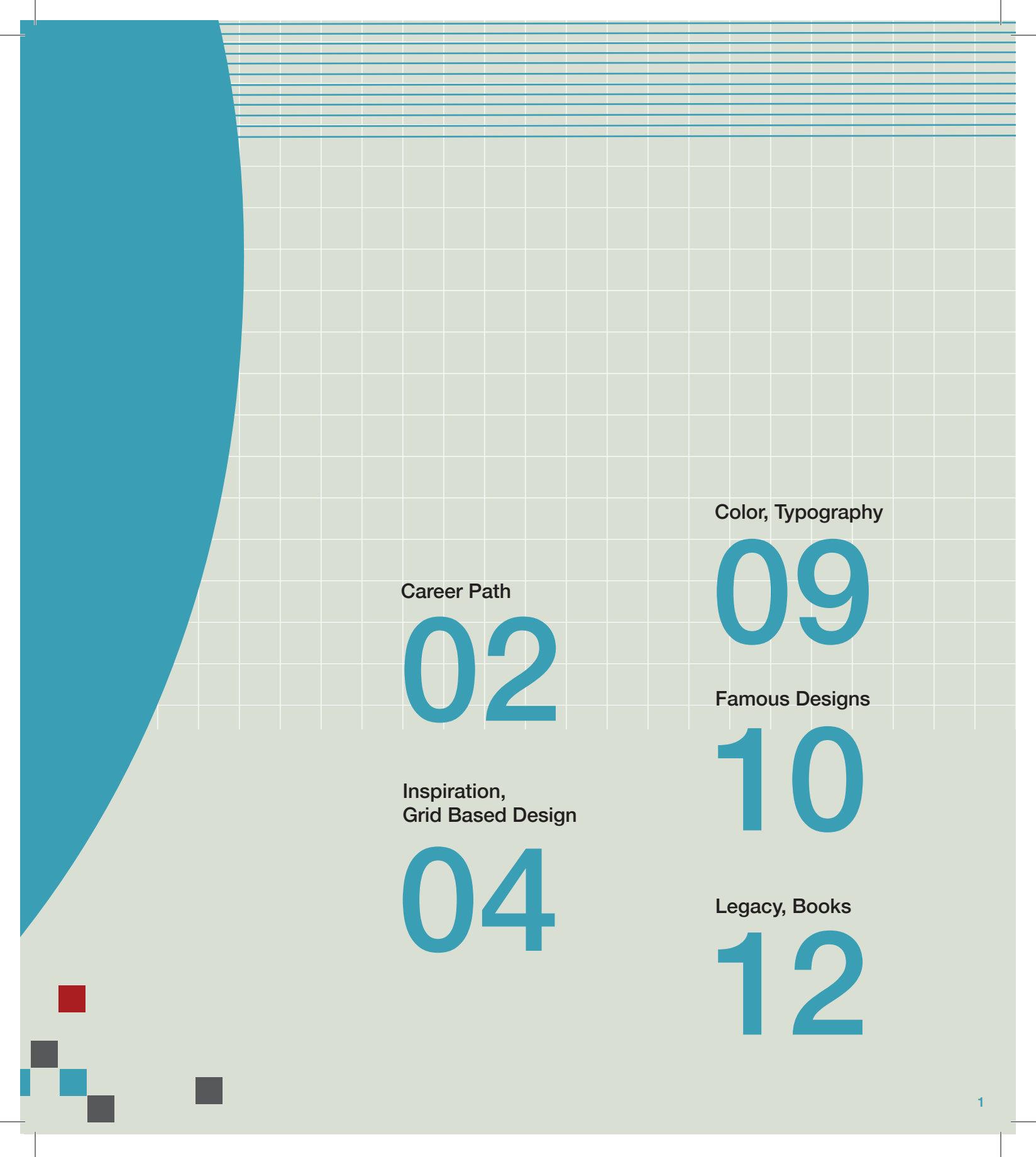
Practicing Precision

1914-
1996



CONTENTS





Career Path

02

Inspiration,
Grid Based Design

04

Color, Typography

09

Famous Designs

10

Legacy, Books

12

Career Path

Josef Müller-Brockmann, a luminary in the world of graphic design, left an indelible mark on the field with his innovative approach and unwavering commitment to precision. Born in Rapperswil, Switzerland, in 1914, Müller-Brockmann's journey as a designer would come to redefine the very essence of visual communication. His legacy, marked by clarity, orderliness, and an embrace of grid-based design, continues to influence designers worldwide.

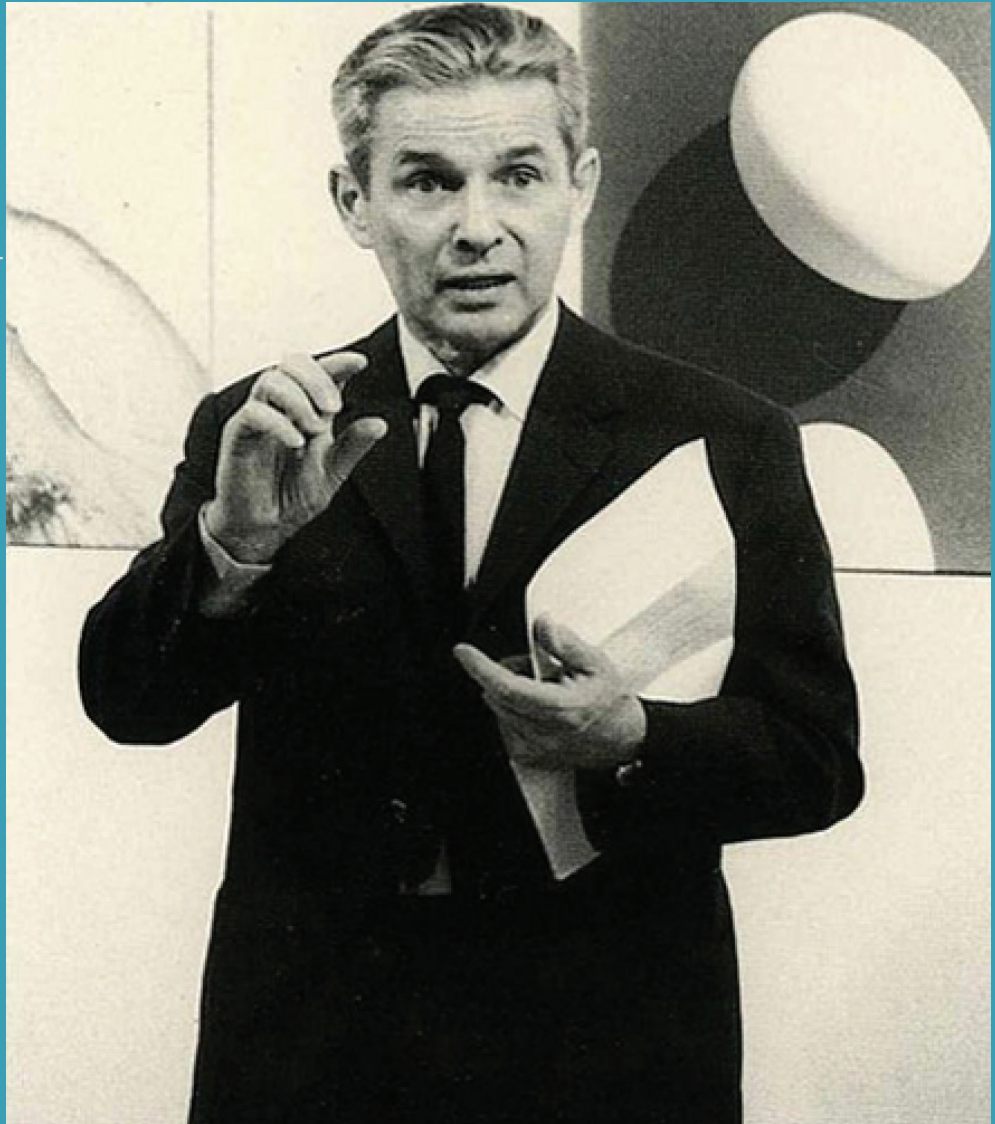
"I became a graphic designer by accident," Brockmann says. "At school, I didn't like writing much so I started drawing. My teacher was impressed, so I realized I had talent. He suggested that I should pursue an artistic career. So I became an apprentice retoucher in a printing house. It only lasted one day because it wasn't artistic enough. After that, I was apprenticed to two old architects. With them, it lasted four weeks. Then I went to all the graphic designers I found in the phone book to find out what they had studied. So I enrolled at the Zurich School of Arts and Crafts."

So, essentially, Müller-Brockmann's career path began with a foundational education at the *Zurich School of Arts and Crafts*, where he cultivated his skills in typography, photography, and visual communication. Inspired by the Bauhaus movement's emphasis on simplicity and functionality, Müller-Brockmann embarked on a journey that would see him emerge as a leading figure in the Swiss School of design.

The late 1940s was when Müller-Brockmann turned toward the constructivist design aesthetic and away from his illustrative and subjective period.



Joseph Muller Brockmann



"I became a
graphic designer
by accident."

A grid system creates a “sense of compact planning, intelligibility, and clarity, and suggests orderliness of design.”

Inspiration

Reaching this constructive approach was a gradual process over many years; an examination influenced by teachers, peers, and social surroundings. Through the rejection of the illustrative method, he acquired freedom for the more highly charged organizational forms that were appropriate to the subject. The belief that graphic design — if it was to inform and enlighten without being manipulative— had to be based on objective criteria, is what led Müller-Brockmann to his turning point.

Müller-Brockmann drew inspiration from various sources, including the *Bauhaus movement* and the Swiss School of design. The Bauhaus's ethos of merging art with craftsmanship and technology deeply resonated with Müller-Brockmann, shaping his belief in the importance of form following function.

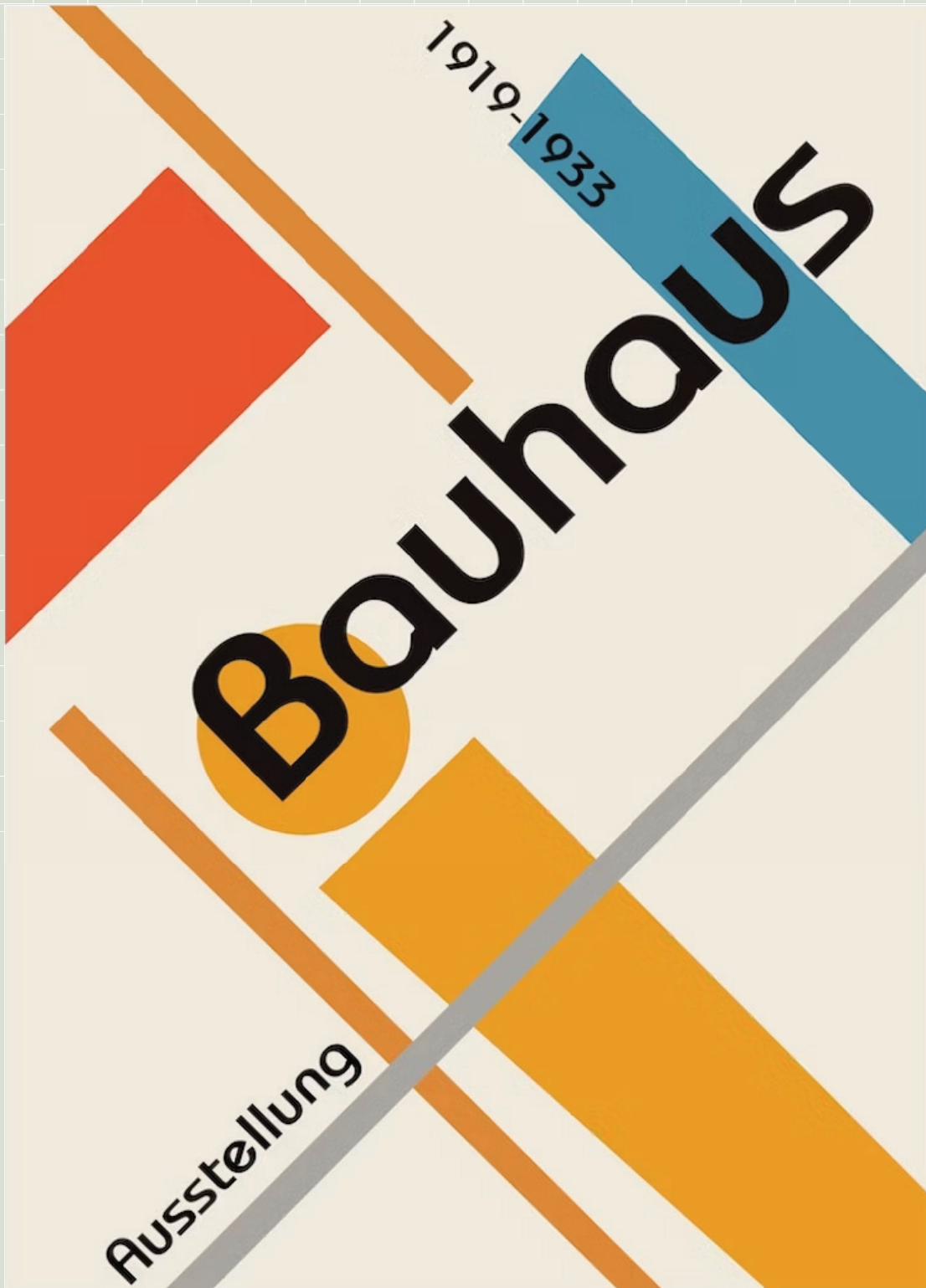
Additionally, the Swiss School's emphasis on clarity, simplicity, and grid-based layouts provided a framework that Müller-Brockmann would adopt and refine throughout his career.

Grid-Based Design

Central to Müller-Brockmann's design philosophy was the use of grid systems to create visually harmonious compositions. He believed that grids provided structure and coherence to designs, allowing for a rational organization of space and elements.

A key part of Müller Brockmann's approach involved the use of the typographic grid. This involved dividing space up into several consistent horizontal and vertical units, each with consistent spacing between them. The grid is used to define the constant dimensions of the design space and elements are inserted precisely into it.

Using the grid as an organizational tool, harmony between image and type was achieved, resulting in a unified composition. In *History of the Poster*, Müller-Brockmann describes a Constructive Poster being composed of, “...linear and proportional correlations between all parts, each is integrated in the whole, and the result is the optimum arrangement for the task.”



Bauhaus, Exhibition Poster

Further, Müller Brockmann said that a grid system creates a “sense of compact planning, intelligibility, and clarity, and suggests orderliness of design. Müller-Brockmann’s adherence to grid-based design was rooted in a quest for orderliness and clarity, enabling him to communicate complex ideas with simplicity and precision.”

Müller-Brockmann’s meticulous attention to detail and his pursuit of visual orderliness were evident in all facets of his work. From typography to layout design, he sought to eliminate superfluous elements and distill his designs to their essence. This disciplined approach not only enhanced the readability and impact of his work but also contributed to its timeless quality.

The Golden Ratio

The golden ratio, also known as the golden proportion, or the divine proportion, is a ratio between two numbers that equals approximately 1.618. Although Greek mathematicians knew about this since about 300 BCE, it wasn’t until early 16th century that Artists and Designers started discussing it. In 1509, Italian mathematician Luca Pacioli published the book *De divina proportione*, which, alongside illustrations by Leonardo da Vinci, praised the ratio as representing divinely inspired simplicity and orderliness.

Müller-Brockmann adeptly applied this principle, ensuring a harmonious balance and captivating visual appeal in his designs.

“The grid system is an aid, not a guarantee. It permits a number of possible uses and each designer can look for a solution appropriate to his personal style. But one must learn how to use the grid; it is an art that requires practice.”

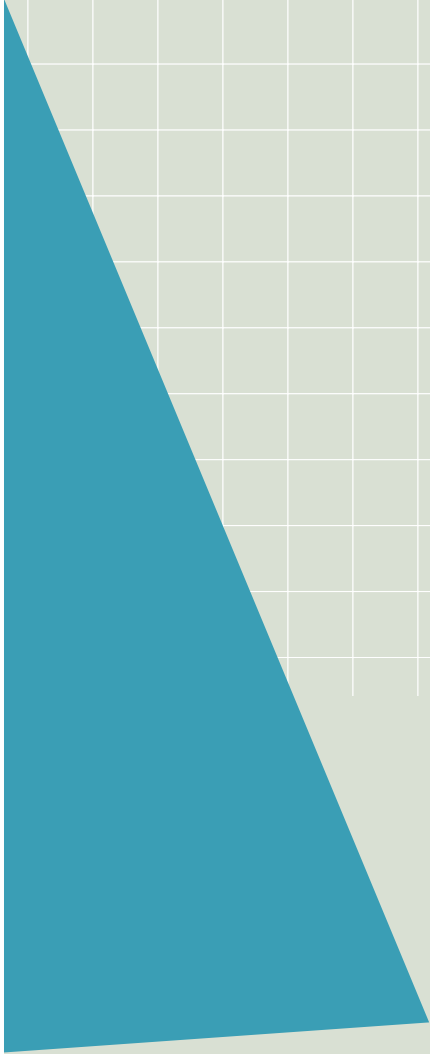
Watch That Child, Swiss Auto Club, 1954





Zurich Town Hall, Music Viva, Concert Poster, 1958

“In purely typographic designs I tried to put the areas into a contrasting tension with areas remaining empty. In its execution I did not rely on my feeling but on measurable proportions.”



Typography

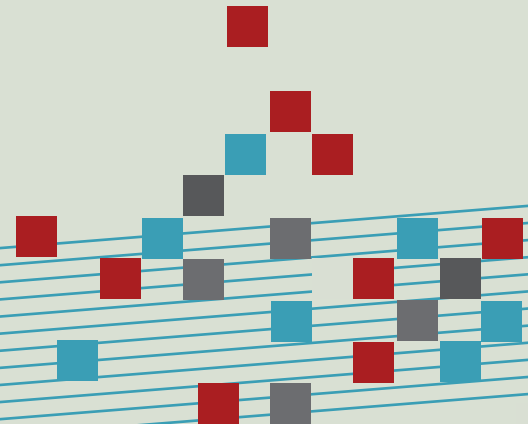
Beyond the quest for legibility, Müller-Brockmann believed that type is “employed so that there is a link (between image and text) that compels attention.” In his opinion, the less elaborate the letterform, the more capacity for function; and that the new typography should be represented with a sans serif typeface. His personal favorite was Berthold’s Akzidenz Grotesk. Even with the newly emergent sans serif faces Univers and Helvetica in the late 1950s (inspired by Akzidenz Grotesk), Müller-Brockmann still preferred Berthold’s design of 1898.

“It is more expressive and its formal foundations are more universal. The end of the “e”, for instance is a diagonal which produces right angles. In the case of Helvetica and Univers the endings are straight, producing acute or obtuse angles, subjective angles.”

Müller-Brockmann’s purely typographic poster solutions can be seen developing in the 1960s. Objectivity had moved one more notch toward pellucid form. At first, these designs were completely unadulterated and this purity was not necessarily well-received by the public. Like all of his work, the posters evolved, and in the late ’60s and early ’70s his wholly typographic poster solutions seemed to be singing to themselves. In his 1994 book *Mein Leben: Spielerischer Ernst und ernsthaftes Spiel*, Müller-Brockmann reflected, “In purely typographic designs I tried to put the areas into a contrasting tension with areas remaining empty. In its execution I did not rely on my feeling but on measurable proportions. The understanding for typographic values gained from various sources. I was essentially influenced by the typography put in practice at the Bauhaus and by Tschichold.”

Color

Color is a key player in elemental hierarchy. In his posters of the early 1960s, Müller-Brockmann pursued purely typographic solutions using color as a vehicle to represent key information to the viewer. The delineation of content was divided by the use of color. This division of content was brilliantly employed in his more structurally complex typographic posters of 1969 and 1970, where color played a staccato effect to punctuate text among the singing display of information.

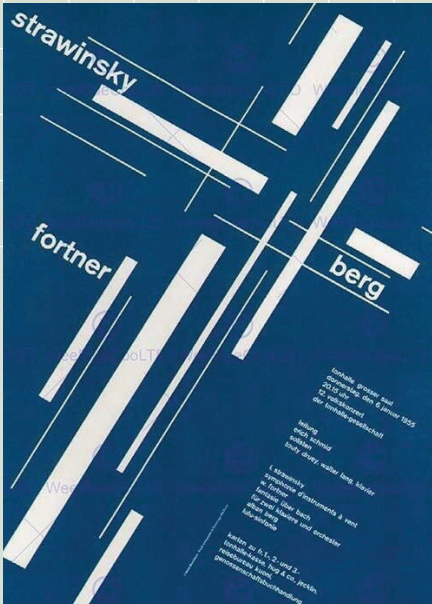




Zurich Town Hall, Music Viva, Concert Poster, 1958



Zurich Town Hall, Concert Poster, 1955



Zurich Town Hall, Concert Poster, 1955



Der Film, Exhibition Poster, 1960



Famous Designs

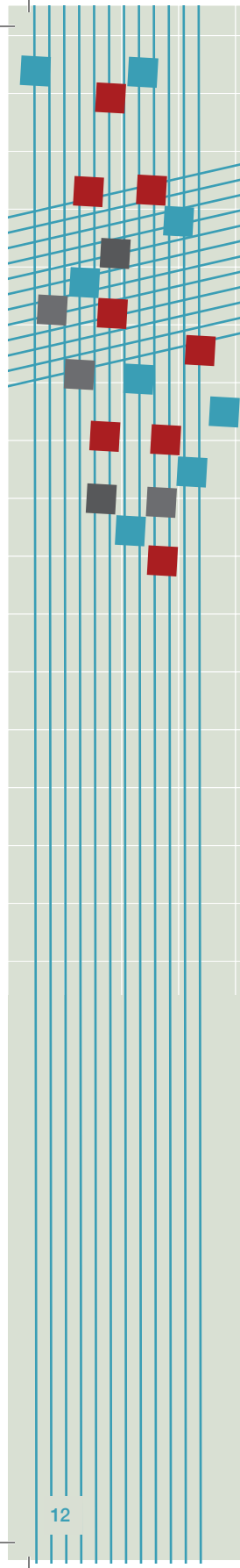
Among Müller-Brockmann's most iconic designs are his posters for the *Zurich Townhall* (1955), where he masterfully combined typography and imagery to promote classical music concerts. One of his most renowned posters features a bold, diagonal composition with stark black-and-white contrasts, capturing the dynamic energy of the music. Müller-Brockmann's use of asymmetry and geometric forms creates a sense of movement and rhythm, echoing the musical experience itself.

"*Beethoven*" Exhibition Poster (1963) is another of Muller's famous works - designed for an exhibition celebrating the life and work of Ludwig van Beethoven, this poster features bold typography and a grid-based layout.

One of the most admired of Müller-Brockmann's posters is the 1960 poster *der Film*. The poster is in the three-to-five ratio of the golden mean, considered the most beautifully proportioned rectangle since Greek times. This design organization grew out of functional communication needs. The title projects clearly at great distances against the field of black. The overlapping of Film in front of der is a typographic equivalent to the cinematic techniques of overlapping images and dissolving from one image to another. For all its elemental simplicity, this poster successfully combines effective communication, expression of content, and visual harmony.

Another notable work is Müller-Brockmann's corporate identity for the Swiss National Exhibition in 1959. Here, he employed a modular grid system to create a cohesive visual identity that extended across various applications, from signage to promotional materials. The result was a unified and easily recognizable brand presence that effectively conveyed the spirit of the exhibition.

"Graphic design —if it was to inform and enlighten without being manipulative— had to be based on objective criteria."



Books

In addition to his poster designs, Müller-Brockmann also wrote several books about design principles.

Out of these, “*Grid Systems in Graphic Design*” remains a seminal work in the field. In this comprehensive guide, he explores the principles and applications of grid-based layout design, offering invaluable insights into his methodology and approach. The book continues to serve as a foundational resource for designers seeking to harness the power of grids in their own work.

In addition, his “*The Graphic Artist and His Design Problems*” aimed to solve the graphic designer’s problem of finding the appropriate contemporary form, became a standard work that still serves as an historic practical guide well beyond the boundaries of Switzerland.

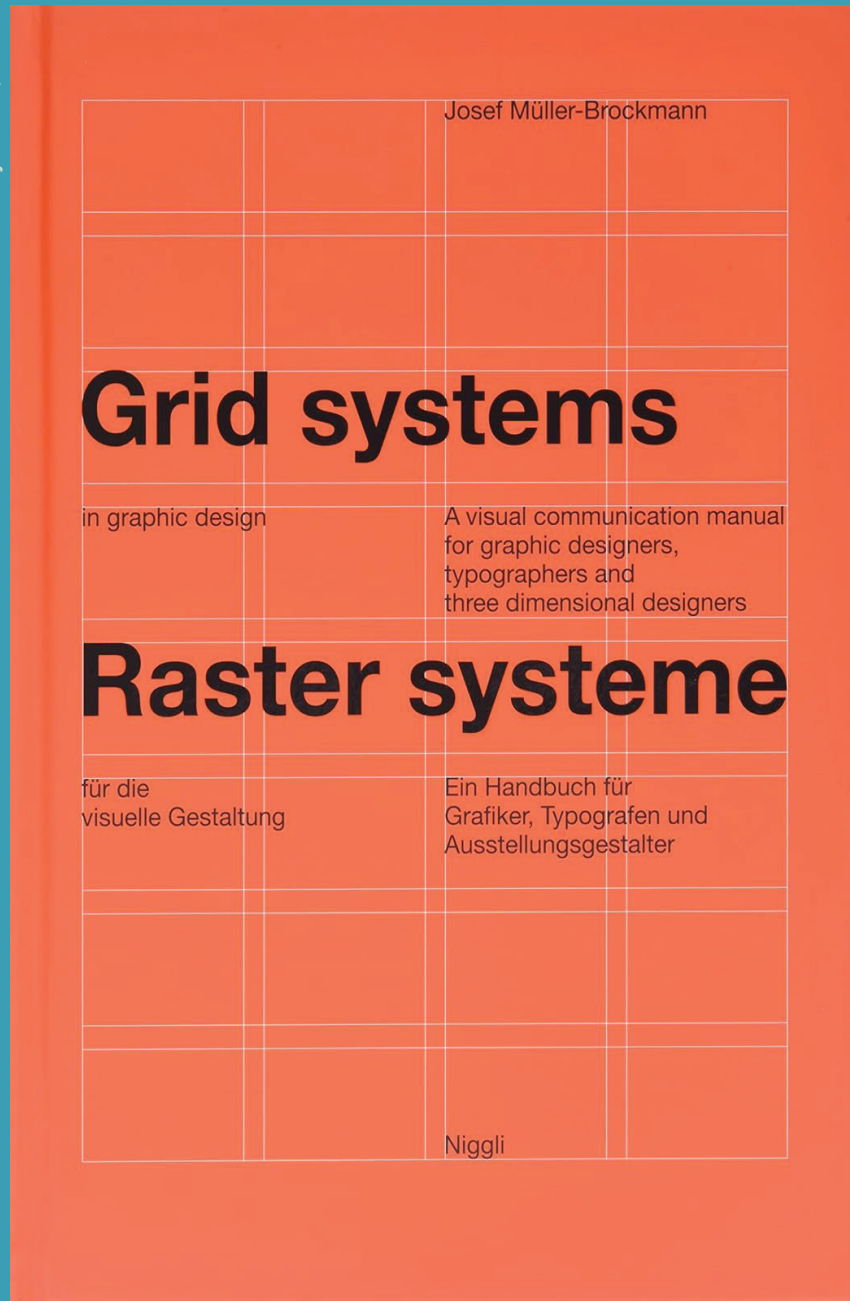
Muller also co-authored “*History of The Poster*”, which presents a richly extensive collection of posters, ranging from the late nineteenth century to the early 1970s, when the book was published for the first time. The book defines the nature of a poster and indicates the laws of designing it.

Legacy

Josef Müller-Brockmann’s legacy as a pioneering figure in graphic design is characterized by his unwavering dedication to precision, orderliness, and innovation. Inspired by the Bauhaus movement and the Swiss School of design, he forged a distinctive aesthetic that continues to influence designers to this day. Through his mastery of grid-based design and his iconic works such as the Zurich Tonhalle posters, Müller-Brockmann demonstrated the transformative potential of visual communication. His legacy serves as a testament to the enduring power of clarity, simplicity, and thoughtful design in shaping our design world.

“Order was
always wishful
thinking for me.”

Grid Systems, 1996



MB

